

Yavuz Selim Kaçmaz

CONTACT INFORMATION

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EDUCATION

University of California, Davis, CA, USA
Ph.D. in Economics, 2024–present

Bogazici University, Istanbul, Turkey
M.A. in Economics, June 2024
B.A. in Economics and History, June 2022

RESEARCH INTERESTS

International Economics, Spatial Economics, Economic History

PUBLICATIONS

“Unequal Outcomes in Unequal Times: The Distributional Consequences of Turkey’s Unorthodox Policies” (with Tolga Umut Kuzubaş, Islam Tarlacı, and Orhan Torul). *New Perspectives on Turkey*, 2025. 73, pp. 32-51.

Abstract: This paper examines trends in wage, income, and consumption inequality in Turkey from 2002 to 2023, a period marked by unorthodox economic policymaking before and after the COVID-19 pandemic. Using microdata from the Turkish Statistical Institute’s Household Budget Survey and the Survey of Income and Living Conditions, we document several salient distributional patterns. Wage inequality declined steadily over two decades, including during the recent episode of policy experimentation—coinciding with sustained minimum wage hikes and a rising share of university-educated workers. Income inequality also fell, though less markedly, before reversing in recent years due to widening disparities in capital and entrepreneurial income. In addition, consumption inequality rose dramatically during the unorthodox policy period, exceeding income inequality growth and driven primarily by a surge in durable goods consumption among top-decile households. These findings reveal the complex and multi-dimensional distributional consequences of unconventional economic policy in emerging markets and highlight the importance of examining inequality across multiple dimensions when evaluating policy effectiveness.

WORKING PAPERS

“Global Markets at the Dawn of Modern Growth: Evidence from Four Centuries of Grain Prices” (with Kıvanç Karaman)

Abstract: This paper investigates market integration on the eve of the takeoff of modern economic growth in the nineteenth century, and uses the findings to reassess the relationship between markets and growth. To this end, we compile a global city-level dataset of annual grain prices comprising 29,397 observations for 119 cities. The data cover Europe and the Middle East from the sixteenth century, and the Americas and Asia from the eighteenth century to the early twentieth century. We measure market integration along two dimensions, price convergence and price synchronization, and disaggregate trends by domestic versus international integration and across geographic regions. The results indicate that integration gains were already evident in the sixteenth century and were initially concentrated in Northwest Europe, before spreading gradually to other parts of Europe and to North America. In contrast, in Asia, market integration advanced only in the late nineteenth century: international integration rose broadly, while domestic integration improved unevenly and appears to have depended on institutional modernization. Overall, these patterns suggest that the timing and geography of market integration anticipated the takeoff of modern economic growth, supporting the view that integration was a precursor to growth, and not merely a consequence.

WORK IN PROGRESS

“Railroad Expansion and Intergenerational Mobility in the United States” (with Jialin Liu)

Abstract: This paper examines the effect of railroad-induced market access changes on intergenerational mobility in the United States between 1850 and 1920. To this end, we link individuals across historical full-count censuses and construct county-level market access measures following Donaldson and Hornbeck (2016). To address endogeneity, we instrument the change in market access with a shift-share instrument that fixes population to a lagged benchmark year and restricts to distant counties. Our main results show that market access improvements reduced intergenerational mobility: sons in counties with larger gains were less likely to move up or down the occupational distribution and less likely to exit agriculture. Heterogeneity analysis reveals two mechanisms. In farming households, market access reduced mobility by raising agricultural returns and anchoring sons in farming. Among sons of non-farmers, railroad connectivity exposed local trades to outside competition, increasing downward mobility. Together, these findings suggest that the aggregate gains from nineteenth-century railroad expansion were accompanied by significant distributional consequences across generations.

“Geopolitical Tensions and Trade Realignment: Evidence from the Suez Crisis” (with David S. Jacks and Christopher M. Meissner)

Abstract: How do geopolitical conflicts reshape global trade networks? When one bloc confronts a nonaligned country militarily, that country—and others observing the conflict—may redirect economic relationships toward the opposing bloc. We study this mechanism using the 1956 Suez Crisis, in which Britain and France militarily confronted Egypt following the nationalization of the canal, as a case study. Using bilateral trade data for 1950–1966 and a structural gravity framework, we find that nonaligned countries persistently shifted trade toward communist partners after the crisis, while trade with Western-bloc countries remained unchanged. On average, trade between nonaligned and communist countries increased by 72 percent relative to trade among nonaligned countries, with the import margin responding more strongly than exports. This realignment was not uniform: it was strongest among country pairs whose shipping routes transited the Suez Canal and among countries whose pre-crisis trade networks depended most heavily on it, indicating that disruption to maritime transport was central to the mechanism. Together, the results show that geopolitical shocks can durably reconfigure international trade, especially among countries and trading relationships most exposed to the underlying disruption.

“What Drives Market Integration? Evidence from European Railroads, 1820-1914”

Abstract: Will be available soon.

PRESENTATIONS

Economic History Coffee Hour, UC Davis 2025
Bay Area Economic History Workshop, UC Berkeley 2025

RESEARCH ASSISTANTSHIP

Title: Tariffs and Economic Development in the USA: New Evidence from a New Dataset of US Product-Level Tariffs, 1789–Present 2025
Investigators: Christopher M. Meissner

Title: Market Integration in the Ottoman Empire, 1550–1914 2022–2023
Investigators: Pinar Ceylan, Kıvanç Karaman, and Şevket Pamuk

SELECTED TEACHING EXPERIENCE

At UC Davis
ECN 110, Global Economic History Spring 2026
ECN 101, Intermediate Macroeconomics Winter 2026
ECN 190, Using Big Data to Solve Economic and Social Problems Winter 2025

	At Bogazici University	
	EC 504, Macroeconomics II (<i>master's level</i>)	Spring 2024
	EC 531, Econometrics I (<i>master's level</i>)	Fall 2023
	EC 358, World Economic History	Spring 2023
	EC 471, Growth and Development	Fall 2022
HONORS, AWARDS, AND GRANTS	Best First-Year Award , UC Davis	2025
	Summer Stipend , UC Davis	2025
	Department Fellowship , UC Davis	2024–2025
	Murat Sertel Award , Bogazici University	2024
	Graduate Scholarship , Turkish Historical Society	2023–2024
	Graduate Scholarship , Turkish Education Foundation	2022–2024
	Valedictorian in the Economics Department , Bogazici University	2022
	Highest-Ranking Double-Major Student , Bogazici University	2022
	Alper Orhon Econometrics Award , Bogazici University	2022
	Undergraduate Double-Major Scholarship , TUBITAK	2021–2022
	Outstanding Success Scholarship , Bogazici University	2016–2022
COMPUTER SKILLS	Scholarship for Turkey's Top 100 , Prime Ministry of the Republic of Turkey	2016–2021
	Golden Youth Prize , Türkiye İş Bankası	2016
Python, R, Stata, MATLAB, L ^A T _E X		